

Freelancer Finance OS

Product Vision & Phased Roadmap

GST-compliant invoicing + automated bookkeeping for Indian freelancers
who work with international clients

Document 1 of 2 — Product Roadmap & Execution Plan
(see Document 2 for Technical HLD/LLD)

Prepared for: Harsh Maurya | Solo founder, part-time build alongside a full-time job

1. Executive Summary

Freelancer Finance OS is a self-serve web platform that helps Indian freelance developers, designers, and consultants — especially those working with international clients — generate GST-compliant invoices, track expenses, and see a real picture of their business profit and tax liability, all in one place. It replaces the current default of Excel sheets, WhatsApp payment reminders, and manually looking up GST rules.

It is designed to be built and run by a single person, part-time, alongside a full-time job, with a starting budget of roughly ₹10,000 and no in-person sales — customers are acquired purely through content and online communities. The roadmap below is phased so that a sellable product exists at every stage, rather than requiring a long build before the first customer.

Dimension	Summary
Target customer	Indian freelance developers/designers/consultants, especially those billing international clients
Core wedge	GST-compliant invoicing + multi-currency/export handling + expense tracking, combined in one tool
Distribution	Content/SEO + Reddit, Indie Hackers, Twitter/X, freelancer communities — zero field sales
Monetization	Freemium: free tier for light usage, ₹500-800/month paid tier for full features
Founder mode	Solo, part-time (~10-15 hrs/week), ₹10,000 starting budget
Backend stack	Django + Django REST Framework + PostgreSQL
Frontend stack	React + TypeScript (see Document 2 for the full comparison against Angular)

2. Problem Statement & Target Customer

2.1 The problem

Freelancers in India who cross ₹20 lakh/year in turnover (₹10 lakh in special-category states) must register for GST and issue invoices with correct HSN/SAC codes, the right CGST/SGST vs IGST split, and sequential invoice numbering. Freelancers who work with clients outside India also need to handle export-of-services rules (LUT, zero-rated GST) and multi-currency billing. On the expense side, freelancers rarely track spending in a structured way, so they don't have a real view of profit or an accurate tax estimate until it's time to file — often in a panic.

2.2 Who exactly this is for (the wedge)

Not "all freelancers" — that market is already served by Refrens, Zoho Invoice, and ClearTax. The specific underserved segment is **Indian freelance developers, designers, and consultants who bill international clients** (via Upwork, direct clients, or agencies abroad). This group needs multi-currency invoicing and export/LUT handling done well — something generic, India-only invoicing tools do not prioritize.

2.3 Example persona

Riya, 27, freelance UI/UX designer in Pune. She bills three clients: two in India (₹40,000 and ₹60,000/month) and one in the US (paid in USD via Wise). She crossed the GST threshold last year and now needs GST-compliant invoices for her Indian clients and export-supply invoices for her US client. She currently tracks everything in a spreadsheet and forgets to log her software subscription expenses, so she has no idea what she actually profits each month.

3. Product Positioning & Differentiation

Competitor	What they do well	Where the gap is
Refrens	Free, popular with Indian freelancers, decent invoicing	Not built around international/export billing or bookkeeping depth
Zoho Invoice / Books	Mature, feature-rich, trusted brand	Built for small businesses generally, not tuned to solo international freelancers; can feel heavy
ClearTax	Strong GST/tax compliance credibility	Focused on filing/compliance, not day-to-day invoicing + bookkeeping UX
Excel + WhatsApp (status quo)	Free, flexible	No compliance checks, no automation, no real financial visibility

Positioning statement: "The financial back-office for Indian freelancers who work with the world" — one place to invoice (in any currency, GST-correct), track expenses, and know your real profit and tax liability.

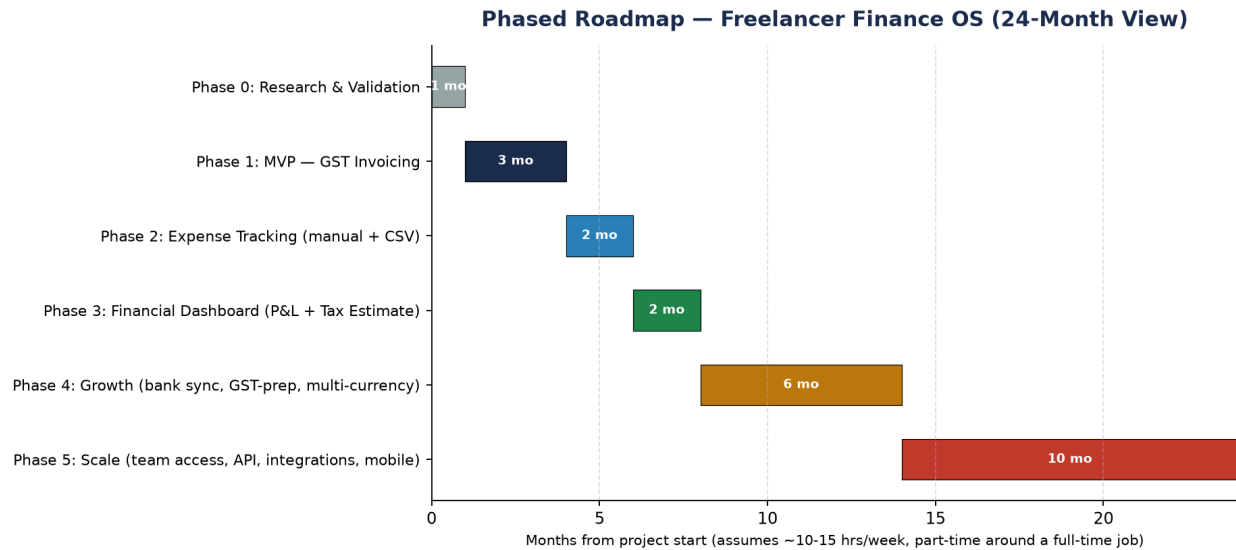
4. Business Model & Pricing

Tier	Price	Includes
Free	₹0	Up to 3 invoices/month, manual expense entry, basic dashboard
Pro	₹499/month (or ₹4,999/year)	Unlimited invoices, multi-currency, CSV expense import, payment reminders, P&L dashboard
Pro+ (Phase 4+)	₹799-999/month	Everything in Pro + live bank/UPI sync + GST return pre-fill assistance

Revenue projection (illustrative, conservative): 100 paying users on the Pro tier ≈ ₹49,900/month. Reaching 100 paying users from a standing start via content/community distribution alone is realistic within 12-18 months if 2-3 pieces of useful content are published consistently each month and shared into the right communities.

5. Phased Roadmap — Overview

The roadmap is split into six phases across roughly 24 months, assuming ~10-15 hours/week of part-time work. Every phase after Phase 0 ends with something real users can pay for — later phases (4 and 5) are only worth starting once earlier phases show real traction, so treat their timing as gated by evidence, not a fixed calendar.



6. Phase-by-Phase Detail

6.0 Phase 0 — Research & Validation (~1 month)

Goal: Confirm the problem and wedge are real before writing code, and gather the exact GST/invoicing details needed to build correctly.

Features:

- Talk to 8-12 freelance developers/designers who bill international clients (DM in communities, no field visits) about their current invoicing/expense workflow and pain points.
- Study 3 competitor tools (Refrens, Zoho Invoice, ClearTax) — sign up, create a test invoice, note gaps for the international-freelancer use case.
- Document exact GST invoice rules needed: HSN/SAC codes for services, CGST/SGST vs IGST logic, export-of-services/LUT requirements, sequential numbering rules.
- Write 1-2 draft landing pages describing the product and collect email signups to gauge interest before building.

Example user story: *As a solo founder, I want to validate that international freelancers feel real pain around invoicing/GST before I spend evenings building it.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): You have 10+ real conversations confirming the pain, a clear GST rules reference doc, and at least a handful of interested signups.

6.1 Phase 1 — MVP: GST-Compliant Invoicing (~3 months)

Goal: Ship the smallest sellable product: create clients, generate correct GST invoices (including export/multi-currency), and get paid.

Features:

- Auth: sign up/login (email + password, JWT-based sessions)
- Business profile setup: business name, GSTIN (optional if below threshold), PAN, state, invoice number prefix
- Client management: add/edit clients, mark as domestic or international, store client GSTIN/country
- Invoice creation: line items with HSN/SAC code, quantity, unit price; auto tax-type detection (CGST+SGST / IGST / export-zero-rated)
- Multi-currency support: invoice in USD/EUR/GBP with an INR-equivalent shown using a daily exchange rate
- PDF generation of the invoice, sequential invoice numbering per BusinessProfile
- Razorpay payment link generation attached to each invoice
- Payment status tracking (Draft / Sent / Paid / Overdue) + manual mark-as-paid
- Email delivery of invoice PDF + payment link to the client

Example user story: *As Riya, I want to create a GST-correct invoice for my US client in USD and send her a payment link, without looking up tax rules myself.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): You have a working invoicing flow end-to-end, have onboarded 10-20 real freelancers (free or paid), and gotten direct feedback on the invoice format and flow.

6.2 Phase 2 — Expense Tracking (Manual + CSV Import) (~2 months)

Goal: Add the 'money out' side so users start seeing a fuller financial picture, without the cost/complexity of live bank integration yet.

Features:

- Expense categories (default set: software, travel, professional services, equipment, etc. + custom categories)
- Manual expense entry (vendor, amount, date, category, optional receipt upload)
- CSV bank/UPI statement upload with column mapping + auto-categorization suggestions (simple keyword rules to start)
- Expense list view with filtering by date range/category

Example user story: *As Riya, I want to upload my bank statement CSV once a month and quickly tag which transactions are business expenses.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): A meaningful share of active users (e.g. 30%+) are logging expenses regularly, not just invoices.

6.3 Phase 3 — Financial Dashboard (P&L + Tax Estimate) (~2 months)

Goal: Combine invoicing (income) and expenses to give freelancers a real, always-current view of profit and estimated tax liability — the core 'OS' value proposition.

Features:

- Monthly/quarterly profit & loss view (income from paid invoices minus categorized expenses)
- Rough GST liability estimate (output tax on invoices minus input tax credit on eligible expenses)
- Rough income tax liability estimate based on presumptive taxation rules commonly used by freelancers (44ADA), shown as an estimate, not filing advice
- Automated payment reminder emails for overdue invoices
- Export P&L and expense data as PDF/CSV for the user's CA

Example user story: *As Riya, I want to open one dashboard and immediately know my profit this quarter and roughly what I'll owe in tax.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): This becomes the main reason free users convert to Pro — track conversion rate from this feature specifically.

6.4 Phase 4 — Growth Features (~6 months (traction-gated))

Goal: Deepen the product once there is real revenue to justify the added cost/complexity of these features.

Features:

- Live bank/UPI transaction sync via an account-aggregator API (replacing manual CSV upload)
- GST return (GSTR-1/GSTR-3B) pre-fill/export assistance
- Recurring invoices for retainer clients
- Multi-currency improvements: historical exchange-rate locking, FIRC/foreign remittance proof tracking for exports
- Basic team access (e.g. inviting a bookkeeper/CA as a read-only collaborator)

Example user story: *As Riya, I want my bank transactions to appear automatically so I never have to upload a CSV again.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): Only start this phase once Phase 1-3 has paying customers actively requesting these — don't build ahead of demand.

6.5 Phase 5 — Scale (~10 months (traction-gated))

Goal: Expand from a single product into a platform, once there's a real business and possibly a small team to support it.

Features:

- Public API access for accountants/CAs managing multiple freelancer clients
- Marketplace-style integrations (accounting software export, e-commerce/freelance platform imports)
- Mobile app (or PWA) for on-the-go invoice creation and expense capture
- Expansion beyond freelancers to very small agencies/2-5 person studios

Example user story: *As a CA managing 15 freelancer clients, I want API access to pull their P&L data for return filing season.*

Exit criteria (move to next phase when): This phase implies hiring and/or raising money — it's the point where the project stops being a solo side project.

7. Solo Execution Plan (Time Management)

Working a full-time job means the biggest risk isn't technical difficulty — it's losing momentum. A realistic weekly rhythm for ~10-15 hours/week:

Day	Suggested focus	Hours
Mon-Fri (evenings)	Heads-down building — pick ONE feature per evening, avoid context-switching	1-1.5 hrs x 4-5 days
Saturday	Deeper build block (bigger features, integrations, debugging)	3-4 hrs
Sunday	Content/distribution: write one post, reply in communities, talk to 1-2 users	1-2 hrs

Rule of thumb: ship something small every single week, even if it's tiny — momentum matters more than speed when this is a nights-and-weekends project. Avoid the trap of "perfecting" Phase 1 for 6 months; the exit criteria above exist specifically to force forward motion.

8. Go-to-Market / Distribution Plan (Zero Field Sales)

Every acquisition channel below is fully remote and self-serve — no cold calls, no in-person meetings.

- **Content/SEO:** write posts like "How to invoice international clients as an Indian freelancer" or "GST for freelancers with foreign clients, explained" — these rank on Google because freelancers actively search for this.
- **Communities:** Reddit (r/developersIndia, r/freelance, r/IndiaTax), Indie Hackers, Twitter/X build-in-public threads, freelancer Discord/Slack groups.
- **Direct value-first outreach:** answer real questions about GST/invoicing in these communities (not pitching), link to the tool only when genuinely relevant.
- **Referral loop:** a small "invoice generated with [product]" footer link on free-tier invoice PDFs (opt-out available) — passive distribution to the client receiving the invoice.
- **Product Hunt / Indie Hackers launch** once Phase 1 is stable, to get an initial burst of signups and feedback.

9. Risk Register

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
GST rules are implemented incorrectly, damaging trust	Medium	Validate tax logic with a CA/tax professional before launch; clearly label tax estimates as estimates, not filing advice
Can't get first 10-20 users without a personal network in this niche	Medium	Start Phase 0 outreach immediately and in parallel with early building, not after
Competitors (Refrens) add international/export features first	Low-Medium	Move fast on the narrow wedge; depth beats breadth against a generalist competitor
Burnout from job + side project	Medium-High	Fixed weekly hour budget (Section 7), ship small increments, take breaks between phases
Scope creep — trying to build Phase 3+ features before Phase 1 has users	High	Enforce the exit criteria in Section 6 strictly before starting the next phase

10. Budget Breakdown (₹10,000 Starting Budget)

Item	Approx. Cost	Notes
Domain name (1 year)	₹800-1,200	e.g. .com or .in
Hosting (backend + DB)	₹0 for first few months	Render/Railway free-hobby tier; upgrade only once there's revenue
Frontend hosting	₹0	Vercel/Netlify free tier
Transactional email	₹0	Resend/Brevo free tier (sufficient at MVP volume)
Razorpay	₹0 upfront	Percentage fee only on actual transactions
Design assets (logo, icons)	₹1,000-2,000	Optional — can also DIY with free tools (Canva)
Buffer / misc (SSL, tools, testing)	₹1,000-2,000	Most tools at this scale have generous free tiers
Reserve	~₹4,000-5,000	Kept aside for Phase 4 (paid account-aggregator API costs) once there's revenue

11. Success Metrics / KPIs to Track

Phase	Primary metric	Target signal to move forward
Phase 0	Validated conversations + landing page signups	10+ confirmed pain points, 30+ email signups
Phase 1	Invoices created, active users	20+ real freelancers using it for actual invoices
Phase 2	% of users logging expenses	30%+ of active users use expense tracking monthly
Phase 3	Free-to-paid conversion rate	5-10% of active free users upgrade to Pro
Phase 4	Monthly recurring revenue (MRR)	₹25,000+ MRR before investing in bank-sync integration
Phase 5	MRR + team readiness	₹1,00,000+ MRR or external funding secured

12. Glossary

GSTIN: GST Identification Number — a business's unique registration number under India's GST law.

HSN/SAC code: Standardized codes used to classify goods (HSN) or services (SAC) on invoices for tax purposes.

CGST / SGST / IGST: Central/State GST (charged on sales within the same state) vs Integrated GST (charged on sales across states or, functionally, exports).

Export of services / LUT: Selling services to a client outside India, which is treated as zero-rated under GST if the freelancer has filed a Letter of Undertaking (LUT).

FIRC: Foreign Inward Remittance Certificate — proof that payment was received from abroad, sometimes needed to support export-of-services claims.

Presumptive taxation (Section 44ADA): A simplified income-tax scheme many Indian freelancers use, taxing a fixed % of gross receipts as presumed profit.

MRR: Monthly Recurring Revenue — predictable subscription revenue expected each month.

Freemium: A pricing model offering a free tier with limited features and a paid tier with full features.

PLG (Product-Led Growth): A growth strategy where the product itself (via free tier, virality, self-serve signup) drives customer acquisition instead of a sales team.

13. Next Steps

Read Document 2 (Technical Design — HLD/LLD) alongside this roadmap when you start building Phase 1. It contains the database schema, API design, sequence flows, and the frontend/backend technology decisions needed to actually start writing code.

Suggested immediate next action: start Phase 0 conversations this week — even 3-4 conversations with freelancers you already know (from work, college, or online) will sharpen every decision that follows.